

The Boston Globe

Serving our community since 1872

TUESDAY, OCTOBER 21, 2025

Most Americans ill-prepared for getting old

Two reports offer stark assessments of impending struggles in health, housing

By Kay Lazar
GLOBE STAFF

The wealthiest older Americans can expect an extra nine years of life, on average, compared to the poorest, a team of Massachusetts researchers concluded in a new report. And that wealth and death gap will only widen, the researchers say, with nearly a trillion dollars in federal cuts to the nation's health care system coming in the next decade.

At the same time, another Massachusetts team has found that most Americans are ill prepared for their senior years, with many not planning for the type of care, housing, finances, and health services they are likely to need as they age in this rapidly changing landscape.

"Wealth is often a stand-in for life-long habits" that provide people access to better health care and other services, said Marc Cohen, an expert

on aging at the University of Massachusetts Boston and a coauthor of the new wealth and death report.

While earlier research has shown that wealthier people tend to live longer, Cohen said the latest data showed a significant gap.

"What shocked me," he said, "was the magnitude of that differential."

The number of Americans 65 and older is projected to increase by more than 40 percent by 2050. And earlier research has found that one-fifth of an individual's life, on average, is now expected to be lived in a

state of illness.

But millions of people, including older adults, are expected to lose much of their ability to afford care for those illnesses because of Medicaid coverage cuts under President Trump's sweeping tax and spending law. Medicaid provides health coverage to 7.2 million low-income seniors nationwide who are also enrolled in Medicare, federal data show. Medicaid also pays for various home care services for seniors and is the primary source of funds for most nursing home residents. Researchers say the

AGING, Page A7

US seeks to bolster cease-fire in Gaza

Envoys, Netanyahu meet as attacks imperil deal; Vance on way to region

By Abbie Cheeseman, Siham Shamalakh, and Lior Soroka
WASHINGTON POST

The Trump administration has ramped up diplomatic efforts to bolster a shaky cease-fire in the Gaza Strip, with Middle East envoy Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner, the son-in-law of the president, meeting with senior officials in Israel on Monday, a day after the Israeli military killed dozens of people in strikes that it said were a response to a Hamas attack.

Witkoff and Kushner met with Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, according to an Israeli government spokeswoman, and Vice President JD Vance is expected in Israel on Tuesday. The visit Monday was aimed at mediating some of the early disputes over the terms of the cease-fire, which went into effect Oct. 10. The agreement, the first phase of a broader US-backed plan to end the war and reconstruct Gaza, calls for a halt to all combat operations, a partial Israeli withdrawal, the return of hostages to Israel in exchange for the release of Palestinian prisoners, and an increase in humanitarian aid.

Almost immediately, the two sides accused each other of violating the agreement, and on Sunday, Israel said it carried out strikes across Gaza after its troops came under fire in Rafah, an area it

MIDEAST, Page A5

A long, bumpy path to recovery

MBTA's ridership woes persist, although some bright spots offer hope



DANIELLE PARHIZKARAN/GLOBE STAFF

Ridership remains below pandemic levels on the subways, with service disruptions and slow rides discouraging commuters.

By Jaime Moore-Carrillo
GLOBE STAFF

Before COVID reared its head, it took Katie Hampton around two hours to get to her company's Cambridge office from her home in Ayer.

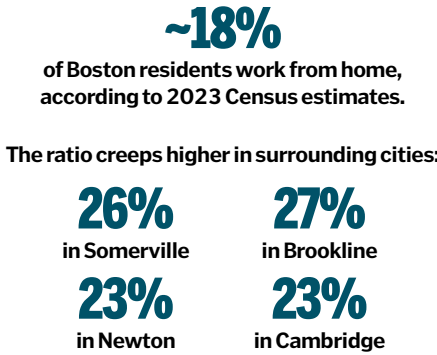
She recalled making the trip four times a week — a commuter rail journey strung together by walks, Red Line rides, and short drives. Then the pandemic hit, and her work life migrated online. Hampton, a graphic designer, now ventures into the office only a few times a month.

"I really love the convenience of being at home. I love that my dogs are happy," she said, adding, "I would do this all the time."

Hampton's story is an emblematic one. Transit ridership plummeted as the pandemic surged. The plunge drained fare revenue, burning gaping holes in the T's budget.

Riders and their dollars have seeped back into the system. But the T has yet to reach its pre-pandemic normal.

"We expect systemwide ridership to continue increasing year over year for the foreseeable future," the agency wrote to the



'Our region is not returning to everybody in the office five days a week. I don't see that happening here.'

KATE DINEEN, CEO of A Better City, a business group involved in transportation research and advocacy

Globe. "However, we are not anticipating a return to pre-pandemic levels in the next five years for all modes."

When the T will regain the riders it lost — assuming it can — has potentially serious implications.

A tenuous recovery in fare-paying ridership could sustain pressure on a T budget already strained by historic debts, ballooning expenses, and other stresses.

Federal cash infusions helped buoy the agency during the worst of the pandemic, but those lifelines are gone.

The state government this year stepped in to help plug a roughly \$700 million MBTA budget deficit for the 2026 fiscal year. An almost \$800 million deficit looms further down the horizon, according to T projections.

How that hole will be patched — with more state assistance, new funding streams, or a crippling cycle of service cuts and layoffs — isn't yet defined.

"No mode of transportation is 100 percent paid for by the user. Every trip is subsidized to a certain extent, even folks who

MBTA, Page A10

Collins's post both a pinnacle, predicament

Mainer navigating Trump, shutdown, and reelection

By Tal Kopan
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — When Republicans retook the Senate majority at the beginning of the year, the moment held special significance for Maine Senator Susan Collins. In January, she became chair of the Senate Appropriations Committee, the first Republican woman to hold the historically powerful position.

It should have been the pinnacle of her nearly three-decade-long career, especially with her party holding full control of Washington. Instead, it's been an onslaught of challenges.

The congressional appropriations committees write the bills that dictate government spending. The chairs, and particularly the leader on the Senate panel, have enormous influence on virtually every aspect of government.

But Collins has faced an administration hell-bent on wresting more control from Congress, including by intentionally testing the boundaries of executive authority by choosing not to spend or to cancel appropriated funds and programs. Rather

COLLINS, Page A7

2025 summit to gather change-makers

Talks will center on 'Revolutionary Ideas' in fifth annual Globe event

By Nick Stoico
GLOBE STAFF

In November, The Boston Globe's fifth annual Globe Summit will bring together researchers, entrepreneurs, executives, politicians, and change-makers from New England and beyond in conversations led by Globe journalists focused on this year's theme, "Revolutionary Ideas."

The Globe Summit takes place Tuesday, Nov. 18, and Wednesday, Nov. 19, at the House of Blues in Boston, with the first day's programming focused on health care and leadership, followed on day 2 by discussions on innovation, community, and commerce.

Speakers include best-selling author Elin Hilderbrand, cultural historian Sarah Lewis, Ben & Jerry's cofounder Ben Cohen, activist and author Bill McKibben, Ken Casey of the Dropkick Murphys, Ben Collins of The Onion, and Massachusetts Governor Maura Healey, along with university presidents, chief executives, city officials, and other influential figures.

The summit will feature a series of 30 forums and can be attended in person and watched online via livestream. Tickets are

GLOBE SUMMIT, Page A10



BLOOMBERG; GETTY IMAGES; ASSOCIATED PRESS

Speakers at the two-day Boston Globe event will include, from left, Governor Maura Healey, Ken Casey of the Dropkick Murphys, and Boston Celtics executive Allison Feaster.

Rays expectations

Tuesday: Beautiful.
High 64-69, low 53-58.
Wednesday: Early showers.
High 63-68, low 45-50.
Sunrise: 7:04. Sunset: 5:53.
Weather and comics, **D5-6**.
Obituaries, **C9**.
VOL. 308, NO. 113
*
Suggested retail price
\$4.00



The state's second-largest insurer, Point32Health, revealed another round of layoffs, the latest sign of the industry's financial problems. **D1**.

An appeals court said the Trump administration can send the National Guard to Portland, Ore. **A6**.

Democrats in the state Senate seek a new oversight panel to track sheriffs' spending and install a receiver to take control of their offices if they fail to meet state-imposed plans. **B1**.

Police raced to find the thieves behind a heist at the Louvre Museum in Paris before the stolen jewelry is destroyed. **A4**.

The Toronto Blue Jays head to the World Series after defeating the Seattle Mariners 4-3 in the seventh game of the ALCS. **C1**.